

UNIT - II

A:-The Revolt of 1857 — The First War of Independence

The Revolt of 1857 was one of the most important uprisings against British rule in India. It began as a revolt of Indian soldiers and soon spread to several parts of northern and central India. It is often regarded as the First War of Independence because it represented a major challenge to British authority.

Causes of the Revolt

- **Political Causes:**

The expansionist policies of the British resulted in the annexation of several Indian states. The loss of political power created resentment among rulers and their supporters.

- **Economic Causes:**

British economic and land-revenue policies adversely affected peasants, artisans and traditional economic groups. Heavy revenue demands and the decline of traditional industries increased dissatisfaction.

- **Military Causes:**

Indian sepoys faced various forms of discrimination and dissatisfaction regarding their service conditions and military policies. These grievances contributed to the growing unrest among soldiers.

- **Social and Religious Causes:**

Many Indians became suspicious of British social and religious policies. Some people feared that British reforms and

missionary activities could interfere with their traditional customs and religious practices.

- **Immediate Cause:**

The immediate cause was the controversy surrounding the Enfield rifle cartridges, which were believed to be greased with cow and pig fat. The issue deeply offended the religious sentiments of both Hindu and Muslim soldiers.

- **Beginning and Spread**

The revolt began at Meerut on 10 May 1857 and soon reached Delhi, where Bahadur Shah Zafar was accepted as the symbolic leader. The uprising spread to important centres such as Kanpur, Lucknow, Jhansi and Bihar.

Important leaders included Rani Lakshmibai, Nana Sahib, Tantia Tope, Begum Hazrat Mahal and Kunwar Singh.

- **Failure of the Revolt**

The revolt was ultimately suppressed by the British. The rebels lacked unified leadership, coordination and sufficient resources. The uprising also remained largely concentrated in certain regions and did not receive equal support throughout India.

Significance

Although the revolt failed to remove British rule, it had major consequences. In 1858, the rule of the East India Company ended, and the administration of India was transferred directly to the British Crown.

The revolt also became an important symbol of resistance to colonial rule and later contributed to the growth of Indian nationalism.

Conclusion

The Revolt of 1857 was a major turning point in Indian history. Although it was unsuccessful militarily, it exposed the widespread dissatisfaction with British rule and became an important milestone in India's struggle for independence.

B: - Important Heroes Of Freedom Struggle

- Birsa Munda:

Birsa Munda was an important tribal leader and freedom fighter of India who belonged to the Munda tribal community of the Chotanagpur region. He opposed British rule and the exploitation of tribal people by British officials, zamindars and moneylenders. He worked to protect the traditional land rights, culture and livelihood of the tribal communities. He led the famous Ulgulan Movement, meaning the "Great Tumult", which became an important tribal uprising against British rule. Birsa Munda united the tribal people and created awareness among them about their rights. He is remembered as a symbol of courage, resistance and tribal pride and occupies an important place in the history of India's freedom struggle.

- Bhagat Singh

Bhagat Singh was one of the most famous revolutionary freedom fighters of India. He was born in 1907 in Punjab and developed a strong spirit of patriotism from a young age. He strongly

opposed British rule and believed that India should become free from colonial control. He was associated with revolutionary organizations and played an important role in spreading the idea of complete independence. Bhagat Singh, along with Batukeshwar Dutt, threw bombs in the Central Legislative Assembly in 1929 as a protest against British policies, while ensuring that the act was not intended to cause mass casualties. He was arrested and later executed by the British government in 1931 along with Rajguru and Sukhdev. Bhagat Singh became a symbol of courage, patriotism and sacrifice and continues to be remembered as one of the important heroes of India's freedom struggle.

- Chandrashekhar Azad

Chandrashekhar Azad was a prominent revolutionary and freedom fighter who played an important role in the Indian independence movement. He was born in 1906 in Madhya Pradesh and became involved in the freedom struggle at a young age. He joined the revolutionary movement and later became an important leader of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association (HSRA). He worked with other revolutionaries, including Bhagat Singh, and strongly opposed British rule. Chandrashekhar Azad was known for his courage, determination and commitment to India's freedom. He remained committed to the revolutionary struggle until his death in 1931. He is remembered as a symbol of bravery, patriotism and resistance against British rule.

▪ Subhas Chandra Bose

Subhas Chandra Bose was one of the most prominent leaders of India's freedom struggle. He strongly opposed British rule and believed that complete independence could be achieved through determined and direct action. He founded the Indian National Army (INA), also known as the Azad Hind Fauj, to fight against British rule. He gave the famous call **"Give me blood, and I will give you freedom"** and inspired thousands of Indians to join the struggle for independence. He also formed the Provisional Government of Free India in 1943. Subhas Chandra Bose became a symbol of courage, patriotism and sacrifice and is remembered as one of the important heroes of India's freedom movement.

C:-Formation of Indian National Congress and Contribution of Mahatma Gandhi

The Indian National Congress was established in 1885 to provide a common political platform for Indians and to promote political awareness and unity. Allan Octavian Hume played an important role in its formation, and the first session of the Congress was held at Bombay in 1885 under the presidency of W.C. Bonnerjee. In its early years, the Congress mainly demanded constitutional reforms, greater representation of Indians in administration and protection of Indian interests. With time, it became an important organisation in the struggle for India's independence.

Mahatma Gandhi played a central role in India's freedom struggle. He introduced the principles of Satyagraha and non-violence as important methods of political struggle. He led major movements such as the Non-Cooperation Movement in 1920, the Civil Disobedience Movement in 1930 and the Quit India Movement in 1942. Gandhi encouraged ordinary people, farmers, workers and different sections of society to participate in the national movement. His leadership transformed the freedom struggle into a mass movement and strengthened the demand for independence. His ideas of truth, non-violence, unity and peaceful resistance became important features of India's national movement.

Making of Indian Constitution and its Salient Features

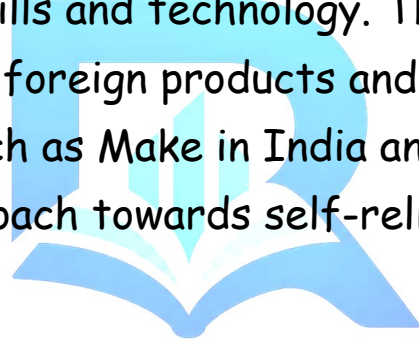
The Constitution of India was prepared by the Constituent Assembly, which was formed to frame a constitution for independent India. The Assembly discussed and debated various provisions before preparing the final document. Dr. B. R. Ambedkar served as the Chairman of the Drafting Committee and played an important role in the making of the Constitution. The Constitution was adopted on 26 November 1949 and came into force on 26 January 1950. It provides the basic framework for the functioning of the government and protects the rights and interests of the citizens.

Salient Features of the Indian Constitution:

1. **Written and Detailed Constitution:** India has a written and detailed Constitution which explains the powers and functions of the government.
2. **Sovereign, Socialist, Secular and Democratic Republic:** India is a sovereign, socialist, secular and democratic republic.
3. **Parliamentary Form of Government:** India follows a parliamentary system in which the Council of Ministers is responsible to the Parliament.
4. **Federal System:** Powers are divided between the Central Government and State Governments, with a strong Centre.
5. **Fundamental Rights:** The Constitution guarantees important Fundamental Rights to citizens, including the right to equality and freedom.
6. **Fundamental Duties:** The Constitution provides certain Fundamental Duties that citizens are expected to perform towards the nation.
7. **Directive Principles of State Policy:** These principles guide the government in making policies for the social and economic welfare of the people.
8. **Independent Judiciary:** The judiciary is independent and protects the Constitution and the rights of citizens.
9. **Universal Adult Franchise:** Every Indian citizen who meets the legal age requirement has the right to vote without discrimination.
10. **Single Citizenship:** The Constitution provides for single citizenship, meaning citizens have Indian citizenship rather than separate state citizenship.

D:-Re-emergence of Swadeshi Movement in India

The Swadeshi idea is based on the use and promotion of goods and services produced within the country. During the freedom struggle, the Swadeshi Movement encouraged Indians to boycott foreign goods and promote indigenous products. After independence, the idea of self-reliance continued in different forms. In modern India, Swadeshi has re-emerged with greater emphasis on domestic production, local industries, entrepreneurship, innovation and the development of Indian skills and technology. The aim is to reduce excessive dependence on foreign products and strengthen the Indian economy. Programmes such as Make in India and Atmanirbhar Bharat reflect this modern approach towards self-reliance and indigenous development.



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Flagship Programmes

- **Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY):**

Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana is a flagship financial inclusion programme launched by the Government of India in 2014. Its main objective is to provide access to basic banking services to people, especially those who were outside the formal banking system. The scheme promotes savings, access to banking facilities, insurance and other financial services. It also helps in the direct transfer of government benefits to beneficiaries through bank accounts. The scheme has played an important role

in promoting financial inclusion and bringing more people into the formal banking system.

- **India Skill Mission:**

India Skill Mission aims to develop the skills and employability of the youth by providing them with vocational and practical training. It focuses on improving the abilities of young people according to the needs of different industries and sectors. Skill development helps individuals gain employment, improve their income opportunities and become capable of self-employment. The mission also supports the development of a skilled workforce and contributes to the economic growth of the country.



- **Make in India:**

Make in India is a major initiative launched by the Government of India in 2014 to promote manufacturing and investment in the country. Its main objective is to encourage companies to manufacture products in India and make India a global manufacturing hub. The initiative promotes domestic production, investment, innovation and employment opportunities. It also aims to improve the business environment and strengthen the Indian manufacturing sector. Make in India supports the broader goal of increasing India's economic growth and reducing excessive dependence on imported goods.

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- **Atmanirbhar Bharat:**

Atmanirbhar Bharat means "Self-Reliant India". It is an initiative aimed at making India more self-reliant by strengthening domestic production, manufacturing, technology, skills and local industries. It gained major importance in 2020 during the COVID-19 pandemic. The initiative focuses on supporting local businesses, small enterprises, innovation, infrastructure, investment and domestic supply chains. Its objective is to increase India's economic strength and reduce excessive dependence on imports while enabling India to become more competitive in the global economy.



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